FOUR YEARS AFTER DELIVERING ONE OF THE FINEST SEASON TWOS, Raj & DK, the most prolific directing duo on OTT (*Farzi*, *Guns & Gulaabs* and *Citadel: Honey Bunny*), finally return with a new instalment of Amazon Prime Video's *The Family Man* (2019-). The show by now is like that favoured first-born; first to take them to heights of soaring success and the one that best exemplifies Raj & DK's brand of fun and thrilling storytelling.

So familiar is the family to them by now that Raj Nidimoru calls the show's writers' room "more relaxed", one where things just flow. Less calculation, more organic is the mantra. "You know the characters really well, the only challenge is to somehow maintain a good balance of familiar and unfamiliar," he says. "You don't want to play too much on the tropes and on the callbacks, but you do want a bit of it." The duo knows how the show is part of pop culture conversation, with memes and reels circulating. The aim, adds Raj, is to be "aware of" what's out there, but "to be real". For Krishna DK—the other half of Raj & DK—the toughest thing about making a sequel is to take everything that people love from the first two seasons and make it refreshing. "The challenge is that it should not feel like an extension, repetition or redux of what you have done," he adds.

The Family Man works best when there's a worthy nemesis to secret agent Srikant Tiwari (played by Manoj Bajpayee). Compared to last season (2021) where Samantha Ruth Prabhu's character kept Tiwari on his toes, this time around, Raj & DK have introduced two antagonists: played by talented actors Jaideep Ahlawat and Nimrat Kaur. The setting, too, has changed to the Northeast, with a chunk of the drama and action unfolding in Nagaland and Assam. According to Raj, creating compelling baddies is the most challenging part of developing a new season—and his preferred way of "scaling up" the show. "It's not by adding more explosions and gravity-defying action sequences, but by thickening the plot and adding emotional complexities," he adds. "The action still stays grounded while it takes two really cool, similar-yet-dissimilar characters to come together to pose the threat."

For Bajpayee, great co-actors is what makes returning to the sets so rewarding. He waxes eloquent about Ahlawat, noting his "sincerity towards his job and choices". "He has been lucky with roles. At the same time, he has shown remarkable improvement as an actor," he adds. "I call him if I see anything fantastic of his and discuss it with him in detail. It feels great that you are seeing up



The directing duo of *The Family Man*, Krishna DK (left) and Raj Nidimoru, is "aware of" the show's popularity and wants it "to be real"

MANDAR DEODHAR